



From Zero to Pro

The Self-Taught Chef Program

A 12-module, self-paced path from your first knife cut
to professional kitchen readiness.

Master Syllabus & Curated Video Library

How this program works

This is a self-paced, beginner-to-professional culinary curriculum built around four pillars: **watch** (credible free video lessons), **study** (reference guides and flash cards), **cook** (hands-on exercises), and **reflect** (homework and a recipe journal). Work through the twelve modules in order; each one assumes the skills from the last. A motivated learner cooking several times a week can complete it in about six months, but there is no clock. Repetition is the point.

What is included

- **Master Syllabus** (this document) with learning objectives and curated, free video links for every module.
- **Reference Library**: knife cuts, mother sauces, cooking methods, temperatures, ratios, conversions, and a glossary.
- **Slide deck** for the keystone knife-skills module.
- **Flash cards** (print & cut) for terms, temperatures, and ratios.
- **Exercises & Homework Workbook** with hands-on drills for each module.
- **Supplies & Equipment List**, tiered from starter to advanced.
- **Interactive Recipe Card** (fillable PDF) for building your personal recipe journal.
- **Course Hub** (open the HTML file) that links everything in one place.

How to use each module

- Read the objectives, then watch the linked videos for that module.
- Review the matching pages in the Reference Library and drill the flash cards.
- Do the hands-on exercises, then complete the homework and log dishes on a recipe card.
- Move on only when you can perform the module's skills without looking at a recipe.

A note on credibility

Every linked resource is free and from a widely respected source: classically trained chefs (Jacques Pepin, Gordon Ramsay), tested-recipe institutions (America's Test Kitchen, ChefSteps), food-science educators (J. Kenji Lopez-Alt, Ethan Chlebowski), working restaurant professionals (Brian Lagerstrom), and government food-safety authorities (USDA FSIS, FoodSafety.gov). Channels and playlists are linked rather than single clips wherever possible, so the references stay valid over time.

MODULE 01 - Weeks 1-2

Kitchen Foundations: Safety, Sanitation & Setup

Before you cook anything, you set up a kitchen that is safe, clean, and organized like a professional line.

Learning objectives

- Practice the core rules of food safety: the temperature danger zone, cross-contamination, and FIFO storage.
- Set up an efficient, sanitary workstation and clean as you go.
- Identify the essential tools and how to maintain them.
- Read a recipe like a pro: scaling, mise en place, and timing.

Topics covered

- Personal & station hygiene; handwashing; the danger zone (40-140 deg F / 4-60 deg C)
- Cross-contamination, color-coded boards, allergen awareness
- FIFO, labeling, fridge/freezer organization and storage temps
- Tool overview: knives, boards, pots, pans, thermometers, scales
- Reading & scaling recipes; understanding mise en place

Watch (free):

[Internet Shaquille \(efficiency & fundamentals\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@internetshaquille](https://www.youtube.com/@internetshaquille)

[Adam Ragusea \(practical home technique\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@aragusea](https://www.youtube.com/@aragusea)

[USDA FSIS - Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart ->](https://www.fsis.usda.gov/food-safety/safe-food-handling-and-preparation/food-safety-basics/safe-temperature-chart)

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[FoodSafety.gov - Safe Minimum Internal Temperatures ->](https://www.foodsafety.gov/food-safety-charts/safe-minimum-internal-temperatures)

<https://www.foodsafety.gov/food-safety-charts/safe-minimum-internal-temperatures>

Homework

- Deep-clean and reorganize your kitchen using FIFO; photograph before/after.
- Print the Temperature & Doneness guide and post it inside a cabinet door.
- Write your own one-page kitchen safety checklist and follow it for one week.

MODULE 02 - Weeks 3-4

Knife Skills & Mise en Place

The single highest-leverage skill in cooking. Speed comes later; first you build safe, consistent cuts.

Learning objectives

- Hold a chef's knife with the pinch grip and use the claw guiding hand.
- Execute the standard cuts: slice, julienne, brunoise, dice, chiffonade, mince.
- Break down an onion, carrot, and herbs cleanly and with minimal waste.
- Hone and understand sharpening; care for your blade.

Topics covered

- Anatomy of a chef's knife; pinch grip & claw
- The standard cuts and their dimensions
- Onion, garlic, shallot, carrot, and herb breakdowns
- Honing vs. sharpening; board setup; safety
- Building mise en place: everything in its place before heat

Watch (free):

Gordon Ramsay - How to Master 5 Basic Cooking Skills -> <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZJy1ajvMU1k>

Jacques Pepin - Techniques & More (KQED) -> <https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8F0CB00AF764>

J. Kenji Lopez-Alt (food science & technique) -> <https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt>

Homework

- The 5-pound onion drill: dice five onions, aiming for even pieces. Save for soups.
- Film your grip and one dice; compare to a Pepin demo and note 3 fixes.
- Prep a full mise en place for one dinner before turning on any burner.

MODULE 03 - Weeks 5-6

Heat & Cooking Methods

Every dish is an application of heat. Learn the methods and you can cook almost anything without a recipe.

Learning objectives

- Distinguish dry-heat (saute, sear, roast, grill, fry) from moist-heat (steam, poach, simmer, braise) methods.
- Control a pan: preheating, fond, deglazing, and the Maillard reaction.
- Choose the right method for a given ingredient.
- Use a thermometer and your senses to judge doneness.

Topics covered

- Conduction, convection, radiation; how heat moves
- Maillard browning vs. caramelization; the role of fond
- Saute & sear; pan temperature and oil smoke points
- Roasting, braising, poaching, steaming, deep- and shallow-frying
- Resting, carryover cooking, and reading doneness

Watch (free):

[Ethan Chlebowski \(the 'why' behind cooking\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski](https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski)

[J. Kenji Lopez-Alt \(food science & technique\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt](https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt)

[America's Test Kitchen \(tested technique\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@AmericasTestKitchen](https://www.youtube.com/@AmericasTestKitchen)

Homework

- Cook the same vegetable three ways (roast, saute, steam); taste side by side and journal.
- Build and reduce a simple pan sauce from fond after searing.
- Sear a protein to a target internal temperature using a thermometer.

MODULE 04 - Weeks 7-8

Stocks, Soups & the Five Mother Sauces

The classical French backbone that underlies most Western cooking. Master ratios and you master sauce.

Learning objectives

- Make clear stock and understand the roux.
- Produce the five mother sauces and several derivatives.
- Build soups: pureed, brothy, and creamed.
- Balance, season, and adjust a sauce to finish.

Topics covered

- White & brown stock; the importance of skimming
- Roux: white, blond, brown; thickening ratios
- Bechamel, Veloute, Espagnole, Tomato, Hollandaise + derivatives
- Emulsions: temporary vs. stable; saving a broken sauce
- Soup architecture and seasoning to taste

Watch (free):

[Jacques Pepin - Techniques & More \(KQED\) -> https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8F0CB00AF764](https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8F0CB00AF764)

[The Complete Pepin Archive \(Jacques Pepin Foundation\) -> https://jp.foundation/video-series/complete-pepin](https://jp.foundation/video-series/complete-pepin)

[Brian Lagerstrom \(ex-restaurant pro, approachable\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom](https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom)

Homework

- Make one stock from scratch and reduce part of it to a glace.
- Produce a bechamel and turn it into a mornay; note the ratio you used.
- Make and rescue a deliberately 'broken' hollandaise.

MODULE 05 - Week 9

Eggs, Dairy & Breakfast Mastery

Eggs are the classic test of a cook. Gentle heat control and timing are everything.

Learning objectives

- Cook eggs every classic way: scrambled (French & American), omelet, poached, fried, boiled.
- Understand custards, curds, and the danger of overheating dairy.
- Make a simple pan crepe and pancake batter.
- Plate a clean breakfast to order.

Topics covered

- Egg structure; how proteins set with heat
- The rolled French omelet vs. the diner omelet
- Poaching technique; the vortex and fresh eggs
- Custards, creme anglaise, and tempering
- Crepes, pancakes, and griddle control

Watch (free):

[Jacques Pepin - The Secret to Perfectly Cooked Eggs \(KQED\) -> https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=As6AY_ChJuI](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=As6AY_ChJuI)

[Jacques Pepin - Techniques & More \(KQED\) -> https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8F0CB00AF764](https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8F0CB00AF764)

[Gordon Ramsay \(knife & cooking basics\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@gordonramsay](https://www.youtube.com/@gordonramsay)

Homework

- Make a rolled French omelet with no browning; repeat until clean.
- Poach two eggs with set whites and runny yolks.
- Make creme anglaise without scrambling it; strain and chill.

MODULE 06 - Weeks 10-11

Vegetables, Grains & Legumes

The foundation of flavor, color, and a modern plate. Treat plants with the same rigor as protein.

Learning objectives

- Blanch, shock, glaze, roast, and puree vegetables.
- Cook rice, grains, and legumes to correct texture.
- Build a balanced vegetarian plate.
- Preserve color, nutrients, and texture.

Topics covered

- Blanching & shocking; seasoning water
- Roasting for caramelization; glazing root vegetables
- Rice methods (absorption, pilaf, risotto); grain ratios
- Dried vs. canned legumes; soaking and salting
- Purees, mashes, and vegetable sauces

Watch (free):

[Ethan Chlebowski \(the 'why' behind cooking\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski](https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski)

[Pro Home Cooks \(skill-building series\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@ProHomeCooks](https://www.youtube.com/@ProHomeCooks)

[J. Kenji Lopez-Alt \(food science & technique\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt](https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt)

Homework

- Blanch and shock a green vegetable; compare to one boiled to death.
- Cook a risotto, stirring for proper creaminess without cream.
- Build a fully vegetarian dinner plate that you would pay for.

MODULE 07 - Weeks 12-13

Proteins I: Poultry & Meat

Butchery basics, the big roasting and braising methods, and judging doneness by temperature.

Learning objectives

- Break down a whole chicken into eight pieces.
- Roast, sear, and braise meat and poultry to target temperatures.
- Understand cuts: which are for fast heat vs. low-and-slow.
- Rest meat and build a pan sauce or jus.

Topics covered

- Whole-chicken fabrication; trussing
- Roasting: high vs. moderate heat; carryover
- Braising tough cuts; collagen to gelatin
- Steak doneness and temperatures; the reverse sear
- Resting, slicing against the grain, and jus

Watch (free):

[Jacques Pepin - Classic Roast Chicken \(KQED\) -> https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sFtpo1nxX_k](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sFtpo1nxX_k)

[J. Kenji Lopez-Alt \(food science & technique\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt](https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt)

[Brian Lagerstrom \(ex-restaurant pro, approachable\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom](https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom)

Homework

- Break down a whole chicken; save the carcass for stock (Module 4).
- Roast a chicken to 165 deg F in the breast and rest it; evaluate juiciness.
- Braise a tough cut until fork-tender; reduce the braising liquid into sauce.

MODULE 08 - Week 14

Proteins II: Fish & Seafood

Delicate, fast, and unforgiving of overcooking. Learn to buy, store, and cook seafood with confidence.

Learning objectives

- Judge freshness and store seafood correctly.
- Pan-sear fish for crisp skin; poach and steam delicate fillets.
- Cook shellfish (shrimp, mussels, scallops) to just-done.
- Portion a fillet and remove pin bones.

Topics covered

- Buying & storing; signs of freshness
- Crisp-skin pan searing; the press-and-wait
- Poaching and steaming; court bouillon
- Shellfish timing; carryover in seafood
- Acid, salt, and finishing seafood

Watch (free):

[America's Test Kitchen \(tested technique\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@AmericasTestKitchen](https://www.youtube.com/@AmericasTestKitchen)

[Ethan Chlebowski \(the 'why' behind cooking\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski](https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski)

[ChefSteps \(modern technique & sous vide\) -> https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCxD2E-bVoUbaVFL0Q3PvJTg](https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCxD2E-bVoUbaVFL0Q3PvJTg)

Homework

- Pan-sear a skin-on fillet to crisp skin without tearing.
- Steam mussels and build a quick pan broth to serve with bread.
- Cook scallops with a proper sear and a barely-warm center.

MODULE 09 - Weeks 15-16

Baking & Pastry Fundamentals

Baking is chemistry with deadlines. Precision, ratios, and a scale replace improvisation.

Learning objectives

- Work by weight; understand baker's percentages.
- Make a basic bread dough and understand gluten and fermentation.
- Produce pie dough, a simple cake, and a custard dessert.
- Understand leavening: yeast, chemical, and mechanical.

Topics covered

- Weighing & baker's percentage
- Gluten development; kneading & rest
- Lamination basics; pie & tart dough
- Creaming, foaming, and the muffin method
- Custards, ganache, and basic plated dessert

Watch (free):

[Brian Lagerstrom \(ex-restaurant pro, approachable\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom](https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom)

[America's Test Kitchen \(tested technique\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@AmericasTestKitchen](https://www.youtube.com/@AmericasTestKitchen)

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Homework

- Bake a simple loaf by weight; log hydration and crumb.
- Make an all-butter pie dough and blind-bake a shell.
- Bake one cake by the creaming method and evaluate crumb.

MODULE 10 - Weeks 17-19

Global Cuisines: French, Italian, Asian & Latin

Apply your fundamentals across four major traditions and learn the pantry and techniques of each.

Learning objectives

- Cook a fresh pasta and an emulsified pasta sauce (Italian).
- Build a stir-fry with wok hei principles (Asian).
- Make a salsa, a braise, and handle masa basics (Latin).
- Execute a classic French bistro plate end to end.

Topics covered

- Italian: fresh pasta, ragu, emulsified sauces, risotto
- Asian: stir-fry, steaming, rice, balance of salt/sweet/sour/umami
- Latin: salsas, braises, beans, masa, marinades
- French: bistro classics tying together earlier modules
- Building a regional pantry and substitutions

Watch (free):

[J. Kenji Lopez-Alt \(food science & technique\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt](https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt)

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Homework

- Make fresh pasta by hand and sauce it with an emulsified butter or tomato sauce.
- Cook a high-heat stir-fry with properly prepped mise en place.
- Prepare one Latin braise plus a fresh salsa to accompany it.

MODULE 11 - Weeks 20-21

Flavor, Seasoning & Menu Development

Move from following recipes to composing dishes. Learn to taste, balance, and design a menu.

Learning objectives

- Season confidently with salt, acid, fat, and heat.
- Diagnose and fix an under-seasoned or unbalanced dish.
- Build flavor with aromatics, herbs, spices, and umami.
- Design a small, coherent multi-course menu.

Topics covered

- Salt, Fat, Acid, Heat as a framework
- Tasting and adjusting; the 'what does it need?' loop
- Building spice blends and aromatic bases (mirepoix, sofrito, mirin)
- Layering umami; finishing techniques
- Menu writing, balance, and cost awareness

Watch (free):

[Ethan Chlebowski \(the 'why' behind cooking\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski](https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski)

[Adam Ragusea \(practical home technique\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@aragusea](https://www.youtube.com/@aragusea)

[Internet Shaquille \(efficiency & fundamentals\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@internetshaquille](https://www.youtube.com/@internetshaquille)

Homework

- Take one bland dish and fix it using only salt, acid, fat, and heat; document each change.
- Develop one original dish and write it as a formal recipe card (template provided).
- Design a three-course menu with a shopping list and timeline.

MODULE 12 - Weeks 22-24

The Professional Kitchen: Line, Plating & Career

Bring it together at professional pace: timing multiple dishes, plating cleanly, and planning a path into the industry.

Learning objectives

- Run a 'service': cook multiple dishes to land together, hot and on time.
- Plate with composition, height, sauce, and garnish.
- Understand the brigade system and kitchen roles.
- Plan a realistic path: stages, apprenticeships, portfolio, certifications.

Topics covered

- Mise en place at scale; the pass and expediting
- Timing and 'firing' multiple dishes
- Plating principles: negative space, height, sauce, garnish
- Brigade system and station responsibilities
- Careers: staging, culinary school vs. self-taught, building a portfolio

Watch (free):

Brian Lagerstrom (ex-restaurant pro, approachable) -> <https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom>

ChefSteps (modern technique & sous vide) -> <https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCxD2E-bVoUbaVFL0Q3PvJTg>

Pro Home Cooks (skill-building series) -> <https://www.youtube.com/@ProHomeCooks>

Homework

- Cook a full three-course meal for guests, plated, all landing on time.
- Photograph your three best plates and write a short tasting note for each.
- Draft a 12-month plan: skills to drill, a target stage, and a portfolio outline.

Complete video & reference library

All linked resources are free to access. Bookmark these channels; they are the core faculty of this course.

[Jacques Pepin - Techniques & More \(KQED\) -> https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8F0CB00AF764](https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8F0CB00AF764)

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[Jacques Pepin - The Secret to Perfectly Cooked Eggs \(KQED\) -> https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=As6AY_ChJul](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=As6AY_ChJul)

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[Adam Ragusea \(practical home technique\) -> https://www.youtube.com/@aragusea](https://www.youtube.com/@aragusea)

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